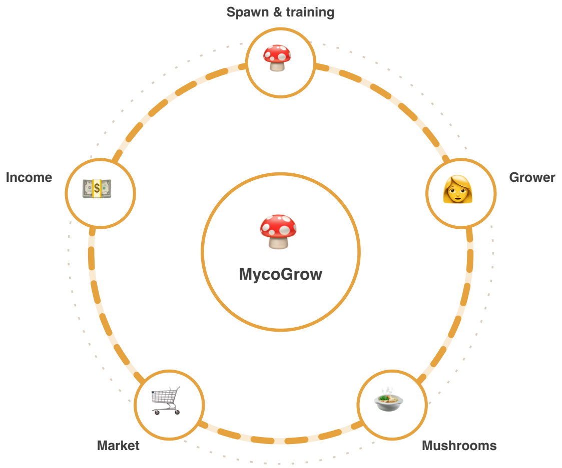
AGRI VALUE-CHAIN

🍄 MycoGrow

Mushroom livelihoods

Low-capital oyster mushroom farming lifts rural Bangladeshi incomes and nutrition



🍄 Spawn & training → 👩 Grower → 🍲 Mushrooms → 🛒 Market → 💵 Income

THE SITUATION IN BANGLADESH

Bangladesh produces roughly 40,000 tonnes of mushrooms a year (worth about Tk 800 crore), yet domestic output still falls short of demand, forcing an estimated Tk 85–90 crore in imports annually [3], even as global mushroom demand climbs about 6.74% per year [5]. The crop grows year-round on cheap, abundant agricultural residue: straw plus a bran supplement delivers around 224 g per bag at roughly 54% biological efficiency, valorizing waste into food [42]. It is also a real livelihood ladder for the landless and for women, who already make up 28% of mushroom entrepreneurs and over 40% of the sector's laborers, with reported benefit-cost ratios of 1.55–4.25 [51]. But the sector is capital-starved at the bottom: only 25% of farmers even attempt a loan and just 5% succeed, leaving 92.8% to self-fund [5].

OUR PITCH

MycoGrow is a micro-franchise network that hands rural Bangladeshis — especially women and the landless — a turnkey kit to grow oyster mushrooms on rice straw and sawdust, the residues already lying around their farms [24]. The wedge is the financing gap itself: by bundling spawn, training, substrate know-how and guaranteed offtake into a low-capital package, MycoGrow replaces the bank loan that 95% of would-be growers never get [5]. The unit economics are honest and modest — typical operators clear single-digit-thousand-taka monthly profits on small investments, but at benefit-cost ratios of 1.55–4.25 and grown vertically in a single room, requiring no cultivable land [1]. It works because every input is local and cheap, demand outstrips a supply gap that already drives tens of crore in imports, and the National Mushroom Development Institute estimates the sector could triple and employ up to half a million people [3].

SOURCES (5)

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